TWO ENGLISH MUGS PODCAST

Stop Studying Grammar, Just Listen

Episode 25 · Full Transcription

Emma & Josh

B1 Intermediate

EMMA: Have you ever stared at a page of grammar rules and, you know, just felt like crying?

JOSH: Oh, absolutely. I mean, I spent an entire weekend last year memorizing these complex verb tables.

EMMA: Wait, an entire weekend?

JOSH: Yeah.

EMMA: That sounds like a terrible way to spend your free time.

JOSH: Yeah, it really was. But I felt like an absolute genius on Sunday night.

EMMA: Whoa. I bet you felt very prepared for the real world.

JOSH: I really did. But then a tourist asked me for directions to a local coffee shop.

EMMA: Oh no. What happened? Did you give him perfect directions?

JOSH: I completely froze. I mean, I forgot every single word.

EMMA: Wait, you couldn't remember the verb tables?

JOSH: Not a single one. My brain was just completely empty. I just pointed down the street.

EMMA: I understand that perfectly.

JOSH: I actually used to hide my heavy French grammar books under my bed.

EMMA: Under your bed? I mean, why not on your desk?

JOSH: Well, because looking at them made me feel guilty. Honestly, this whole topic today feels like a lazy idea to me.

EMMA: A lazy idea? What do you mean by that?

JOSH: You claim that just sitting around listening to people talk is enough. That is basically cheating.

EMMA: I strongly disagree.

JOSH: Okay.

EMMA: It is actually the smartest cheat code in the world.

JOSH: I highly doubt that. I mean, listening sounds way too easy to actually work.

EMMA: Hello, and welcome to Two English Mugs, where we learn English through real everyday conversations. I'm Emma.

JOSH: And I'm Josh.

EMMA: Today, we are exploring why listening teaches you English far better than a grammar book.

JOSH: And we are going to talk about how you can start doing that today.

EMMA: Exactly. It is time to stop hiding those books under the bed.

JOSH: Right. But before we go any further, I need to clear something up for everyone listening.

EMMA: Oh, please do. What is the important announcement?

JOSH: So this is a B1 or intermediate English lesson.

EMMA: That is a very important thing to know.

JOSH: Yeah. It means this is not baby English. We aren't going to talk like slow robots.

EMMA: But it is not super advanced either. We keep things, you know, clear and simple.

JOSH: Right. And we explain any new words right away. Oh, and the PDF transcript is down in the description.

EMMA: Perfect. Now, I want to talk about that lost tourist again.

JOSH: Ugh, do we have to?

EMMA: It is a really embarrassing memory.

JOSH: Yes, we have to.

EMMA: Yes, we have to. Think back to that exact moment on the street.

JOSH: Okay. Well, he asked for the coffee shop and I just panicked.

EMMA: If he had spoken slower, would you have helped him?

JOSH: Well, yeah. If he had spoken slower, I would have pointed him to the best coffee shop.

EMMA: Aha. Did you catch what you just did?

JOSH: Catch what? I just answered your question honestly.

EMMA: You actually just used a very difficult grammar structure perfectly.

JOSH: I did? I mean, I was just talking about coffee.

EMMA: Yeah. You used the third conditional.

JOSH: The third conditional? That sounds like a scary disease.

EMMA: Right. It is a famous grammar rule, but you did not build that sentence by thinking about rules.

JOSH: No, I definitely did not think about a rulebook.

EMMA: Exactly. You built it because you have heard that specific pattern 100 times.

JOSH: Yeah, I guess I have heard it a lot in movies and regular conversations.

EMMA: Well, that is called invisible teaching.

JOSH: Invisible teaching. I kind of like the sound of that. Requires zero pens.

EMMA: Zero pens and zero headaches. You learn without even realizing you are learning.

JOSH: That really does sound like a magic trick.

EMMA: Well, today I promise to show you how to use this magic trick every single day.

JOSH: Oh, I am completely ready for a magic trick.

EMMA: So I'm going to share 3 important points with you today.

JOSH: Okay, 3 points. I can definitely handle 3 points.

EMMA: Number 1 is a weekend of rules.

JOSH: Right, like my terrible weekend with the verb tables.

EMMA: Exactly. And number 2 is ears first.

JOSH: Ears first. Okay, so what is number 3?

EMMA: Well, I am holding back the 3rd point for now.

JOSH: Wait, you are keeping a secret from me?

EMMA: Yes, I am. It is a secret challenge for the end of the episode.

JOSH: A secret challenge? Now I'm actually really curious. So let's start with number 1.

EMMA: Okay, point number 1 is a weekend of rules.

JOSH: I am ready to talk about the rules.

EMMA: Let's look back at history. Why do we even use heavy grammar books in schools?

JOSH: Uh, because old teachers love to give us difficult homework?

EMMA: Well, that might be a little bit true, but there is a real historical reason.

JOSH: A historical reason? Did some king invent grammar homework?

EMMA: Not a king. Hundreds of years ago, these rules were used to teach Latin.

JOSH: Latin? You mean the language from ancient Rome with the men in white robes?

EMMA: Yes. But here is the crazy fact about teaching Latin in schools.

JOSH: Oh, I am ready for the crazy fact.

EMMA: Latin was already a dead language. Literally nobody was speaking it in the kitchen.

JOSH: Wait, so nobody was walking around asking for a slice of bread in Latin?

EMMA: No. Nobody was buying shoes in Latin either. It was a silent language.

JOSH: Then why were they learning it? That makes absolutely no sense.

EMMA: Well, people only learned Latin to read very old, dusty books in silent rooms.

JOSH: So they just stared at paper all day long?

EMMA: Exactly. They translated words very slowly and wrote down strict rules.

JOSH: Right. They needed rules to understand dead sentences on a page.

EMMA: Yes, because they never had to actually talk to a living Roman person.

JOSH: Well, that makes sense. A dead Roman will never ask you for directions to a coffee shop.

EMMA: Exactly. You have all the time in the world to check your book.

JOSH: But English is a living language. People speak it everywhere all the time.

EMMA: And that is the whole problem. We are using a dead language method today.

JOSH: Oh, so we are trying to speak a fast, living language using rules for a dead one?

EMMA: Yes. It is completely backwards.

JOSH: Oh, that explains why it feels so strange and difficult.

EMMA: It does feel strange.

JOSH: Honestly, it can be very frustrating.

EMMA: Oh, let's stop right there. That is a great word. Frustrating.

JOSH: Frustrating. Is that like some kind of sour fruit?

EMMA: Not a fruit. Frustrating means making you feel annoyed when you can't do something.

JOSH: Oh, like when I try to open a tight jar of pickles for 10 minutes?

EMMA: Yes. Your hands hurt, the jar will not open, and you feel angry. angry. That is frustrating.

JOSH: Or like when I try to remember a verb table and a tourist just stares at me.

EMMA: Exactly. Learning a living language with dead rules is deeply frustrating.

JOSH: But I have to admit something. Grammar actually feels very safe to me.

EMMA: Safe?

JOSH: Yeah.

EMMA: Why does a page of rules feel safe?

JOSH: Well, it didn't— in a neat little box. I know exactly what is right and what is wrong.

EMMA: I agree, it feels safe on paper. But think about cooking for a minute.

JOSH: Oh, I love cooking. Well, I love eating.

EMMA: Grammar is exactly like reading a heavy recipe book.

JOSH: I love recipe books. They have beautiful, shiny pictures of perfect food.

EMMA: Sure, and you can sit on your couch and read a recipe book 3 times.

JOSH: I could memorize all the ingredients for a giant chocolate cake.

EMMA: You totally could. You can learn the exact cooking times and the oven temperatures.

JOSH: I would be a world-class chef in my own mind.

EMMA: Do you actually know how to cook that cake?

JOSH: Well, I know the steps.

EMMA: But knowing the steps is not cooking. You do not know how to cook until you stand up.

JOSH: Right, until I walk into the actual kitchen.

EMMA: Yes. You have to turn on the hot stove, and you have to make a total mess.

JOSH: Well, this reminds me of the time I tried to bake fresh bread from a book.

EMMA: Oh, really? Did you make a mess?

JOSH: I covered the entire kitchen floor in white flour. It looked like it snowed inside.

EMMA: Exactly. Reading the book did not teach you how sticky dough actually is.

JOSH: It was incredibly sticky. It got on my nose and it was stuck in my hair.

EMMA: You had to feel the sticky dough with your own hands to truly understand it.

JOSH: I definitely felt it. I mean, it took 3 days to clean the kitchen.

EMMA: Language is exactly the same thing. The recipe book is the grammar textbook.

JOSH: So my long weekend with the verb tables was just me sitting on the couch.

EMMA: Yes, you were just reading a recipe for English.

JOSH: And when the tourist spoke to me on the street—

EMMA: He threw you straight into a messy kitchen, and you did not know how to cook.

JOSH: I really did not. He looked at me like I was a broken statue.

EMMA: Because your brain was trying to read a recipe book instead of just cooking.

JOSH: That makes total sense. I was looking for the page instead of listening to the man.

EMMA: Which brings us perfectly to point number 2.

JOSH: My ears are ready. Tell me about point number 2.

EMMA: Point number 2 is ears first.

JOSH: Ears first. How does that help me in the messy kitchen?

EMMA: Well, think about reading. When you read a book, the words sit perfectly on the white page.

JOSH: Yeah, they are very polite.

EMMA: They do not move around at all.

JOSH: They just wait for you.

EMMA: You can take your time and read a sentence 5 times.

JOSH: I can even use a pencil to underline the tough parts.

EMMA: But real human speech is completely different. Real speech is incredibly fast.

JOSH: It is so fast. Sometimes native speakers sound like machine guns.

EMMA: And real speech is very messy.

JOSH: Messy? You mean like my kitchen floor after I bake bread?

EMMA: Yes. Messy means not neat or mixed up. Real speech is totally mixed up.

JOSH: How is speech mixed up?

EMMA: Words run together. Sounds disappear. Native speakers swallow half the letters.

JOSH: That is so true. People never politely say, what are you going to do today?

EMMA: Never. What do they actually say in the real world?

JOSH: They just say, whatcha gonna do? It sounds like one giant word.

EMMA: Exactly. Whatcha gonna do? Strict grammar rules cannot catch real, messy speech.

JOSH: Right, because the rulebook expects perfect words with spaces between them.

EMMA: Exactly. Your eyes cannot help you here. Your ears have to do the heavy work.

JOSH: I have to admit, sometimes Real speech makes me feel completely overwhelmed.

EMMA: Let's pause right there. Overwhelmed. That is a very powerful word.

JOSH: Overwhelmed. It kind of sounds like a big wave crashing on me.

EMMA: That is a great picture. Overwhelmed means feeling like things are just too much to handle.

JOSH: Exactly. Like when someone speaks super fast and I feel like I am holding 10 hot coffees.

EMMA: 10 hot coffees. That sounds pretty dangerous.

JOSH: Yes. And then they hand me another coffee. The cups burn my hands. I am overwhelmed.

EMMA: That is a brilliant way to describe it. Your brain just drops all the cups.

JOSH: Yeah. All the coffee spills. I just nod my head and pretend I understand.

EMMA: Well, every learner has dropped the coffee cups, but how do we fix this problem?

JOSH: Please help me. I am very tired of spilling hot coffee everywhere.

EMMA: We look at living proof. We look at small children. They are the ultimate proof.

JOSH: Children? Like little babies playing on the floor?

EMMA: Yes. A baby does not hold a grammar textbook.

JOSH: But I am an adult. I have a job. I can't just act like a baby.

EMMA: I am not telling you to act like a baby. I just want you to look at how they learn.

JOSH: Okay. So how does a baby learn such a complicated language?

EMMA: They just listen. They listen to the television playing cartoons in the background.

JOSH: Oh, and they listen to the dog barking at the mailman.

EMMA: They listen to their parents arguing about what to make for dinner.

JOSH: And they do not take any notes?

EMMA: No notes at all. They do this for 3 entire years.

JOSH: 3 whole years of just sitting there and listening. No exams. No weekly vocabulary tests.

EMMA: None. Teachers call it a silent period. They just take the messy language in.

JOSH: They just absorb all the noise.

EMMA: Like a little sponge.

JOSH: Yes.

EMMA: And then suddenly one day they walk into the kitchen and ask for a cookie.

JOSH: And they use perfect grammar to ask for that cookie.

EMMA: Exactly. They speak perfectly because their ears did all the heavy lifting first.

JOSH: You know, we actually want to hear from you.

EMMA: Yes, we do. We love hearing about your experiences.

JOSH: So finish this sentence in the comments below. The hardest thing about understanding native speakers is—

EMMA: That is a fantastic question. I'm sure we will get some very interesting answers.

JOSH: I bet a lot of people will say the crazy speed is the hardest part.

EMMA: Or maybe the strange street slang words, but Listening actually fixes all of that.

JOSH: Okay. How does it fix it? I really need to know why this works.

EMMA: I will tell you why. The human brain is an amazing pattern machine.

JOSH: A pattern machine?

EMMA: Yes.

JOSH: Like a factory robot building cars?

EMMA: Sort of. Give your brain enough messy English, and it figures out the rules automatically.

JOSH: It figures them out completely on its own? That sounds way too good to be true.

EMMA: It really is true. Think about your favorite music.

JOSH: Oh, I listen to a lot of music while I drive my car.

EMMA: You hear a brand new song on the radio 10 times. What happens next?

JOSH: I suddenly know all the words, even if it is a really terrible song.

EMMA: Exactly. You sing along perfectly. Did you study the song lyrics with a notebook?

JOSH: No, I never wrote anything down. I just tapped my fingers on the steering wheel.

EMMA: Your brain heard the song over and over again, and it slowly connected the sounds.

JOSH: It learned the order of the words without even asking my permission.

EMMA: Yes. So your brain is secretly working hard while you just sit there and enjoy the music.

JOSH: I kind of like the idea of feeding the machine. It sounds relaxing.

EMMA: Every single time you listen to English, you feed the pattern machine.

JOSH: And the machine just builds the grammar rules inside my head.

EMMA: Exactly. You have to give your ears the power. They are much smarter than

JOSH: My heavy grammar books are probably crying in the dust under your bed right now.

EMMA: They can stay in the dust because now we are finally ready for the 3rd point.

JOSH: Finally, the secret point. I have been waiting very patiently for this one.

EMMA: Point number 3 is 30 easy minutes.

JOSH: 30 minutes? Well, that does not sound scary at all.

EMMA: It is not scary, but this is my challenge for you and for everyone listening today.

JOSH: Challenge? Are we going to fight in a boxing ring?

EMMA: No boxing matches today. Challenge means something a little difficult but very good for you.

JOSH: Oh, I understand. Like forcing myself to wake up early to go for a cold run.

EMMA: Yes, that is a healthy challenge. Your challenge is this: listen to English for 30 minutes.

JOSH: 30 minutes? Like every single day, 7 days a week?

EMMA: Every single day, rain or shine. But there is a catch.

JOSH: Ah, I knew there was a catch. What are the rules of this challenge?

EMMA: There are strict rules. No checking grammar books. No using translation apps.

JOSH: No dictionaries at all?

EMMA: None. And absolutely no trying to translate in your head.

JOSH: Translate? Do you mean packing a bag and traveling across the ocean?

EMMA: No, not travel. Translate means to change the foreign words into your own language.

JOSH: Oh, I see. Like hearing the English word apple and thinking of the word in my language.

EMMA: Yes. Stop doing that immediately. It slows your brain down way too much.

JOSH: Because real speech is too fast?

EMMA: Exactly.

JOSH: I cannot translate 10 hot coffees at once.

EMMA: Exactly. Just let the messy English words wash over you like a warm shower.

JOSH: What if I do not understand a specific word? Do I just ignore it?

EMMA: Yes. Just ignore the missing word and keep listening. Try to understand the big picture.

JOSH: So I just sit and listen for 30 minutes. But what exactly should I listen to?

EMMA: Let me tell you a personal confession. This is how I learned to understand spoken Spanish.

JOSH: Really? You did not use thick Spanish textbooks in a classroom?

EMMA: I hated My Spanish textbooks. They were incredibly boring, so I found a different way.

JOSH: What did you do? Did you move to a beautiful beach in Spain?

EMMA: I wish. No, I actually started watching dramatic Spanish soap operas on television.

JOSH: Soap operas? You mean those dramatic shows with all the crying and the loud slapping?

EMMA: Yes. They were completely amazing. I desperately needed to know who was marrying who.

JOSH: Wait, you are telling me I can watch soap operas and magically learn a language? That sounds like a scam.

EMMA: It is not a scam. The drama was just too exciting to miss. I had to pay attention.

JOSH: You really cared about the characters that much?

EMMA: I wanted to know if the evil twins stole the family money. I never opened a dictionary.

JOSH: But did you actually understand the fast words they were saying?

EMMA: Not at first. It was a messy blur of fast sounds. But I watched the actors' angry faces.

JOSH: Oh, so you watched their body language?

EMMA: Yes. I heard their emotional voices. And over time, my brain just cracked the code. I understood the Spanish.

JOSH: That is a wonderful story. It actually reminds me of my grandfather.

EMMA: Oh, did your grandfather watch dramatic soap operas too?

JOSH: No, he did not care about evil twins. He watched baseball games on Sunday afternoons.

EMMA: Baseball is a very complicated game. How did you learn the rules?

JOSH: I learned all the complicated rules just by sitting on the couch and watching it with him.

EMMA: Did your grandfather ever give you a printed rulebook to read before the game?

JOSH: Never. We just ate salty snacks and watched the players hit the ball.

EMMA: But there are so many strange terms in baseball.

JOSH: I know. At first, I had absolutely no idea what a strike or a home run was.

EMMA: But you figured it out without reading anything.

JOSH: Yes. I heard the loud announcer scream. I saw the fast players run around the dirt.

EMMA: Your brain just connected the dots naturally.

JOSH: Exactly. It was pure enjoyment. I loved spending time with him.

EMMA: That is the magic word— enjoyment. Enjoyment is the absolute key to this entire method.

JOSH: Because if the listening practice is boring, I will just fall asleep on the couch.

EMMA: Exactly. If you are bored, your brain simply stops listening. The machine turns off.

JOSH: The pattern machine packs a bag and goes on a long vacation.

EMMA: Yes. You have to pick podcasts, funny videos, or upbeat songs you actually love.

JOSH: So I can listen to videos about cooking huge meals or repairing fast cars?

EMMA: Yes. If you love cars, watch car videos in English. If you love video games, watch gaming streams.

JOSH: It does not have to be a serious teacher talking in front of a whiteboard?

EMMA: Not at all. Real people talking about real everyday things is the absolute best practice.

JOSH: That sounds like a lot of fun. 30 minutes of actual fun every day.

EMMA: And when you do that, your ears will naturally start to pick up the patterns.

JOSH: Patterns? Like the ugly striped patterns on my favorite winter shirt?

EMMA: Nice guess. But in this case, a pattern is something that repeats over and over again.

JOSH: Oh, like a habit. Or like the word gonna showing up in every single sentence.

EMMA: Exactly. That is a speech pattern. You hear it often and you just learn it automatically.

JOSH: No strict rules or verb tables needed. My poor brain can finally relax.

EMMA: I am starting to believe that my ears really are smarter than my textbook.

JOSH: They absolutely are. You just have to trust them to do their job.

EMMA: So 30 minutes a day, no heavy dictionaries, no translating in your head.

JOSH: Just Finding the invisible patterns in fun audio.

EMMA: That is the recipe for real success, not a recipe for a kitchen disaster.

JOSH: I like that much better than burning dry bread and spilling flour everywhere.

EMMA: Me too. Now, before we go, think about the fun journey we just took today.

JOSH: We definitely covered a lot of ground today.

EMMA: We started out feeling annoyed by grammar, which brings us to our words. The first word is frustrating. Repeat after me.

JOSH: I hope everyone is saying it out loud at home.

EMMA: Frustrating. It means making you feel annoyed when you can't do something.

JOSH: Trying to find my lost car keys in the morning is incredibly frustrating.

EMMA: Word number 2 is messy.

JOSH: Repeat after me.

EMMA: Messy.

JOSH: Say it loud and clear.

EMMA: It means Not neat or mixed up.

JOSH: My dog always makes a very messy pile of toys in the living room.

EMMA: Word number 3 is overwhelmed. Repeat after me.

JOSH: Take a deep breath for this one.

EMMA: Overwhelmed.

JOSH: Take a deep breath for this one.

EMMA: It means feeling like things are just too much to handle.

JOSH: When my boss gives me 5 heavy jobs at once, I feel completely overwhelmed.

EMMA: Word number 4 is translate.

JOSH: Repeat after me.

EMMA: Translate.

JOSH: Let's hear it.

EMMA: It means to change foreign words into your own language.

JOSH: I asked my smart friend to translate the menu because I really wanted the chicken.

EMMA: Word number 5 is challenge.

JOSH: This is a really fun one.

EMMA: Challenge. It means something a little difficult, but very good for you.

JOSH: Eating a giant spicy red pepper is a fun challenge for me.

EMMA: And our final word is pattern. Repeat after me.

JOSH: Last one, guys.

EMMA: Pattern. It means something that repeats over and over again.

JOSH: I noticed a funny pattern. It rains every single time I wash my dirty car.

EMMA: Great everyday examples. Let's hear the words one last time. Frustrating, messy, overwhelmed, translate, challenge, pattern.

JOSH: I feel smarter already. Those are great words for the real world.

EMMA: They are very useful for natural conversations. Now let's look back at our 3 points from today.

JOSH: Point 1 was about the terrible weekend of rules.

EMMA: Yes. Grammar feels safe on paper, but it fails you when you step into the messy kitchen of real life.

JOSH: Right. And point 2 was putting our ears first.

EMMA: Exactly. Real speech is fast and messy. Your ears can catch the patterns that the strict rules always miss.

JOSH: And little babies prove that it works perfectly.

EMMA: And point 3 was the secret 30 easy minutes.

JOSH: That is your challenge for the week. 30 minutes of daily listening.

EMMA: No checking rules and absolutely no translating in your head.

JOSH: Just pure fun and enjoyment. I can definitely do that while I drive.

EMMA: If you enjoyed our warm conversation today, please give this episode a like.

JOSH: And please hit subscribe right now so you never miss a fun conversation with us.

EMMA: Thank you so much for your time today, and we hope to see you back here next week.

- **JOSH:** And make sure to take care of your family.
- **EMMA:** Have a truly great rest of your day. So next time you put on your headphones, ask yourself, are you actually listening or are you just waiting to translate?

Vocab Unwind

6 key words and phrases from this episode

#	WORD	MEANING	ANALOGY	EXAMPLE
1	**frustrating**	making you feel annoyed when you can't do something	like a door that will not open	*Trying to find my lost car keys in the morning is incredibly frustrating.*
2	**messy**	not neat, or mixed up	like a room after a party	*My dog always makes a very messy pile of toys in the living room.*
3	**overwhelmed**	feeling like things are just too much to handle	like five doors opening at once	*When my boss gives me five heavy jobs at once, I feel completely overwhelmed.*
4	**translate**	to change foreign words into your own language	like changing money at the airport	*I asked my smart friend to translate the menu because I really wanted the chicken.*
5	**challenge**	something a little difficult, but very good for you	like climbing a hill, not a mountain	*Eating a giant spicy red pepper is a fun challenge for me.*
6	**pattern**	something that repeats over and over again	like the same song every morning	*I noticed a funny pattern. It rains every single time I wash my dirty car.*